

Chapter 4 The Origins of Irredentist Conflict: Opportunity, Willingness, and Nationalism

Abstract

Existing studies of irredentism assert that opportunity (and/or grievances) prompt kin states to annex foreign territories based on shared ethnic ties. These studies overlook another crucial factor: the willingness of kin states. In this chapter, I theorize that political leaders who bolster their regimes through nationalist rhetoric and policies are more willing to make cross-border territorial claims based on shared ethnic ties. For empirical testing, I use a sample data of actual and potential irredentist cases in all countries from 1946 to 2014. Rare-event logistic regression provides robust evidence that nationalist leaders' increased willingness is a significant and consistent predictor of irredentist conflict. This empirical evidence aligns with two historical cases: Slobodan Milošević of Serbia and Park Chung-Hee of South Korea. Overall, this chapter suggests that leader nationalism helps explain irredentist conflict when it is properly understood as the product of kin states having both the opportunity and the willingness to engage in irredentism.